

Modifiers & Sentence Logic

Study Guide - Language & Editing

1. Learning goal

Place descriptive and limiting words where they clearly modify the intended person, thing, action, or condition.

2. What this skill means

A modifier adds information, but its position controls meaning. Misplaced words such as only, nearly, or almost can change what a sentence claims. Introductory phrases can also dangle if the person doing the action is not named immediately afterward.

3. Do not confuse it with

Compare "Only staff may enter" with "Staff may enter only after 8 a.m." The same word changes the rule depending on placement. Also compare "After reading the report, Maya revised it" with "After reading the report, the errors were revised." Only the first names who did the reading.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask for the clearest modifier placement, a revision of a dangling modifier, or a sentence whose word order expresses the intended meaning.

5. Repeatable method

- Find the modifier or introductory phrase.
- Ask exactly what word or idea it should describe.
- Place the modifier next to that target.
- Check whether the subject after an introductory phrase actually performed the action.
- Reread for unintended meanings created by only, nearly, almost, or similar words.

6. Worked example

After reviewing the safety log, the supervisor revised the checklist.

Question: Why is the modifier clear?

Reasoning: The phrase "After reviewing the safety log" describes the supervisor, and supervisor appears immediately after the phrase.

Best answer: The sentence clearly identifies the supervisor as the person who reviewed the log.

7. Common traps

- Letting an introductory phrase describe the wrong noun.
- Placing only too far from the word or condition it limits.
- Choosing a grammatically smooth sentence that changes the intended meaning.

8. Diagnostic help

- If a sentence sounds strange, ask who actually performed the action in the opening phrase.
- If only is present, move it mentally and notice how the meaning changes.
- If two choices are grammatical, choose the one that places the description closest to its target.

Why this matters in ER: Precise modifier placement prevents your ER from accidentally changing the scope of a source claim.

9. Quick check

To reduce delays, the team changed only the morning check-in process.

What does only limit?

Check yourself: Only limits the morning check-in process; the sentence does not say every process changed.